



The City-States

THE OVERLORDS

The most influential people in the Western Reaches are the overlords of the five city-states. There is no higher power above them, and they have many military and financial resources.

City of Masks. The largest city-state. Led by Duke Loren di Montmar, who was a knight general before inheriting his father's title. Most trade in the Reaches flows through the city, either down the coast to its ports or along the rivers and paths that extend from it. The city is a powerful center of knowledge, culture, and military strength.

Alkesh. The oldest city-state. The City of Red Sands grew up around a deep well in the Djurum Desert. The young Shar Yasmila holds power, and she is well loved by her people for her shrewd wisdom. Merchant caravans brave the harsh dangers of the desert to bring silk, gold, and horses to the city.

Stonehall. The primary domain of the dwarves, located in the Rimespire Mountains. King Roggen Iverlord, their white-bearded leader, has ruled from the Granite Throne for a century. The reclusive dwarves trade in iron ore and precious metals, but they rarely leave their halls.

Kyzian Tribes. The Kyzian Princes rule over a roving tribe of horse riders the size of a city-state. Each prince leads a loose group of several families who wander the Kyzian Steppes. They sometimes war amongst themselves, but they set aside these squabbles in service of Taru the Hawk Queen, their legendary half-elf warlord.

Lydonia. In the gloomy northern Sablewood, a white citadel reaches its slender spires up through the trees. This is the stronghold of the King of the Wood, Saren Sindalian. Though his city-state is small, his knights and rangers reach far, and much trade passes through Lydonia.

THE CITY-STATES

Name	Ruler	Main Populations
City of Masks	Duke Loren di Montmar	Humans
Alkesh	Shar Yasmila	Humans
Stonehall	King Roggen Iverlord	Dwarves
Kyzian Tribes	Taru the Hawk Queen	Humans, half-elves
Lydonia	King Saren Sindalian	Elves

NOTABLE FEATURES

Name	Known For...
City of Masks	Robust trade, high culture, universities, festivals
Alkesh	Being able to buy anything for the right price, wealthy merchants, ancient customs and laws
Stonehall	Superior metalworkers and builders, reclusiveness
Kyzian Tribes	The best horses and archers, fierce warriors
Lydonia	Legendary knights and rangers, the uncanny and fey nature of the white citadel

MAIN PROBLEMS

Name	Details
City of Masks	The Thieves' Guild, the secret evil society of The Shroud, fears of the Rat Plague
Alkesh	Banditry along trade routes, trained thieves and assassins (Ras-Godai) who act with near impunity
Stonehall	Digging too deep, isolationism, throne succession
Kyzian Tribes	Orc incursions from the Gilzai Mountains, infighting between the princes
Lydonia	The spread of cursed Marrow trees from The Gloaming, ancient dangers that roam the woods

Merging The Rules

This book and the *Player's Guide to the Western Reaches* use variations on the core rules in *Shadowdark RPG*, listed here.

Unless otherwise noted, use *Shadowdark RPG*'s core rules.

CAROUSING

Use the standard rules in *Shadowdark RPG* core or the expanded carousing rules in *Cursed Scroll 6*.

There are limits to the size of carousing events PCs can buy based on the settlement.

Seeking out the best places to go carousing is part of adventuring in the Reaches!

CAROUSING LIMITS

Settlement	Limit
Hamlet	100 gp
Village	600 gp
Town	1,200 gp
City	None

NEW RANDOM ENCOUNTER TABLES

Several new terrain types in the Western Reaches don't have a random encounter table in the core *Shadowdark RPG* rules.

See the Random Encounters chapter (pg. ##) for roll tables for these new terrain types.

ADVENTURING

Hex Crawling. Use the alternate rules from CS 4 (see pg. 42).

Climate. The Reaches have new rules for general and extreme weather (pg. 44).

MOUNTS

This setting uses an adaptation of the mount rules from CS 2 (see PGWR pg. ##).

LUCK

There are additional luck rules specific to the Western Reaches (see PGWR pg. ##).

Sandboxes

OPEN-ENDED

Sandbox settings have many rumors and threads scattered across a large area rather than an overarching story to follow.

Encourage the players to actively pursue what interests them. The world will grow and respond to their choices, but nothing will happen if they sit idle.

Wandering Too Far. Sandbox settings are improvisational and flexible. This creates the illusion that the world is a huge place without limits or ends. But in reality, it's possible for PCs to "wander off the map."

If you want to keep exploring those distant places, use the tables in *Shadowdark RPG* to generate the larger world.

SEEDING RUMORS

It's better to give your players too many rumors than too few. Be generous with the hooks on the Rumors table (pg. 36).

MULTIPLE PCS

In sandbox campaigns, players are not limited to playing just one character. Instead, they can rotate between multiple PCs with differing goals.

It's normal for groups to have PCs of varying levels as the players mix and match the right team for a given rumor or goal they're pursuing.

It can help group cohesion if the PCs have a shared overall purpose, such as being in the same or allied factions. See PGWR pg. ## for the four most prominent character factions in the Western Reaches.

Slow Healing. Using Grinder Mode (*Shadowdark RPG* pg. 111) can encourage players to develop multiple PCs. While one PC is resting or using downtime, another can be out adventuring.

See Passage of Time on pg. 33 for related information about handling downtime.

West Marches

WEST MARCHES

West Marches is a gameplay style popularized by Ben Robbins in his blog, *Ars Ludi*.

West Marches games use sandbox-style campaign worlds paired with open tables (large groups of players with open invites to play). Players then attend sessions as they wish.

It's an excellent way to manage a campaign set in the Reaches.

SCHEDULING

Some GMs create availability time slots and then leave scheduling in the players' hands. The players decide who wants to go on what missions based on their own in-game interests. They tell the GM their plans (with some lead time), and off they go.

Other GMs run sessions at the same time on a regular basis, and everyone who shows up plays (sometimes with a necessary cap on group sizes).

OPEN TABLES

Open table games present special considerations for campaign management.

Quantum PCs. To keep things tidy, PCs should always return to safety at the end of their sessions. This ensures players never accidentally have their characters appearing in two separate places at once.

See **Back to Town** if the PCs get stuck outside of safety at the end of a session.

Dedication. Some players are more driven or available than others. They play often, leveling their PCs up in a blitz. Consider requiring players to rotate between characters so no single PC vastly outpaces their peers.

Communication. Many West Marches groups favor online chat platforms like Discord where players can discuss rumors, plan their next moves, and coordinate scheduling.

PASSAGE OF TIME

Fixed Time. With a fixed time campaign, you manually track the passage of time as the PCs undertake activities and rests.

This method makes it easy to skip forward when needed, and many GMs use the standard rest and healing rules in *Shadowdark RPG* core when tracking time this way.

Real Time. *Shadowdark RPG* already embraces real-time mechanics, and you can expand this to track days, weeks, and months in your game.

A popular technique from the early days of fantasy TTRPGs was to sync the passage of in-game time with the passage of real-world time between sessions. Days, seasons, and even years move along with the outside world. It's easy to track.

Using a slow healing mode, such as **Grinder Mode** (*Shadowdark RPG* pg. 111) enhances the impact of this time tracking method. Time matters much more when it's always a resource, even between sessions.

BACK TO TOWN

Did the characters take the long way out of the dungeon and get waylaid by a random encounter at the very end of the session?

Escaping an adventuring site is even more important in a game where the PCs must return back to safety after each foray.

If you want to enforce this style of play, have PCs who get stuck in an adventuring site at the end of a session roll on the below table. Some GMs might decide to skip this and abstract the PCs' return to safety in other ways.



CAUGHT OUTSIDE!

d6 Details	
1	Disaster! DC 12 CON or you perish in the dungeon
2	You're lost for a week and return at 1 HP with no gear
3	You lose 1d4 pieces of gear in the fight to escape
4	You barely make it out alive, returning with 1 HP
5	You return safe but rattled; you must rest for 1d4 days
6	You return to town safely, no worse for the wear

Hex Crawling

Use the below hex crawling rules from *Cursed Scroll 4* for overland travel in the Western Reaches.

TRAVEL PER DAY

Hexes are **6-miles** across. The PCs can enter a number of hexes per day based on travel method.

MOVEMENT

PCs move from hex to hex as a group while traveling overland. Shift into combat or crawling rounds if an encounter occurs.

Check for a **random encounter** twice a day and twice overnight with a 1:6 chance each time.

WEATHER

Check the weather each day by rolling a d6. On a 1, the weather is terrible (3:6 chance of a storm). On a 6, it's exceptionally good.

Depending on the season, the weather can impact movement, visibility, or how easy it is for the characters to rest.

ENTERING HEXES

Travel Method	Hexes per Day
Walking	4
Mounted	6
Sailing	8

TERRAIN TYPES

Terrain	Hex Cost to Enter
Normal	1
Difficult	2
Impassable	Cannot enter

FOOD AND WATER

PCs and mounts can go three days without consuming a ration. They take 1d4 CON damage per day after that (death at 0). A PC can **forage** for 1 ration a day with an INT check.

PUSHING

At the start of the day, the PCs can choose to push. They move an additional 50% of their speed. Increase the random encounter chance by 1:6 that day. PCs can't forage on a day they push.

TERRAIN IN THE REACHES

Terrain	Type	Hex Cost to Enter
Arctic sea	Impassable without boat	1
Coast	Normal	1
Desert	Normal	1
Forest	Difficult	2
Grassland	Normal	1
Jungle	Difficult	2
Lake	Impassable without boat	1 with boat
Lava	Impassable	-
Mountain	Difficult	2
Ocean	Impassable without boat	1 with boat
River	Difficult	2
Path	Normal	1
Salt Flat	Normal	1
Swamp	Difficult	2
Volcano	Difficult	2



Climate

The Western Reaches are home to a wide variety of climates. Many of them can pose extreme dangers to adventurers.

SPRING/FALL

Most regions have moderate weather in the **spring** and **fall**. Temperatures are generally safe.

Bad Weather. Extreme temperatures in regions marked with an asterisk*. Storms last for one day and cause normal terrain to become difficult.

SUMMER/WINTER

The weather is the most extreme in the **summer** and **winter**. Storms can be deadly.

Regions marked with a dagger† experience extreme cold or heat at all times in these seasons.

Bad Weather. Extreme temperatures in regions marked with an asterisk*. Storms last for 1d4 days and are so harsh that overland travel is impossible.

EXTREME HEAT

- DC 15 CON check to benefit from rest.
- All creatures must consume double rations or be treated as if they consumed none.

EXTREME COLD

- DC 15 CON check to benefit from rest. Failure results in 1d4 CON damage (death at 0).

ISLES OF ANDRIK

This northernmost part of the Western Reaches experiences full seasons of long-term day and night.

Midnight Sun. Spring and summer. The sun never fully sets. There is enough light to see clearly outside at all hours.

Harvest. Fall. Sunny during the day and dark at night.

Long Dark. Winter. Night never ends. Only dark-adapted creatures can see without light.

CLIMATE IN THE REACHES

Region	Spring/Fall	Summer	Winter
Bastion Mtns	Temperate	Temperate	Cold*
Dhalpurna Mtns	Temperate	Hot	Cold*
Djurum Desert	Hot*	Scorching†	Hot
Duchy of Montmar	Temperate	Hot	Cold
Gilzai Mtns	Hot*	Scorching†	Hot
Gloaming, The	Temperate	Temperate	Cold*
Isles of Andrik	Cold*	Temperate*	Freezing†
Kyzian Steppes	Temperate	Hot*	Cold*
Last Sea, The	Temperate	Temperate	Cold
Lowland Moor	Temperate	Temperate	Cold*
Rimespire Mtns	Cold*	Temperate	Freezing†
Sablewood	Temperate	Temperate	Cold*
Silent Mtns	Hot*	Scorching†	Hot
Tal-Yool Jungle	Hot*	Sweltering†	Temperate

† Extreme temperatures at all times

* Extreme temperatures in bad weather



Regions

The Western Reaches contain 16 distinct regions and eight major landmarks (descriptions starting on the facing page).

Below is a table of the terrain types in each region listed in their order of prominence and importance in that region.



TERRAIN BY REGION

Region	Terrain
Bastion Mtns	Mountain, river, coast
Dhalpurna Mtns	Mountain, river
Djurum Desert	Desert, path, salt flat
Duchy of Montmar	River, coast, grassland, path
Gilzai Mtns	Mountain, river
Gloaming, The	Forest, swamp, river, path
Isles of Andrik	Arctic sea, coast, mountain, forest, river
Kyzian Steppes	Grassland, lake, path, river
Last Sea, The	Ocean, arctic sea, forest, mountain, jungle, lava, volcano
Lowland Moor	Swamp, river, coast
Morzomotha	Deep tunnels
Myre Swamp	Swamp
Rimespire Mtns	Mountain, river, lake, path, coast
Sablewood	Forest, river, lake, path, coast
Silent Mtns	Mountain
Tal-Yool Jungle	River, jungle, mountain, volcano, lava, path, coast

BASTION MOUNTAINS

Towering blue-and-purple peaks that cut across the middle of the Reaches like a wall of armored soldiers. They join the Dhalpurna Mountains where they bend to the south, blocking off the Tal-Yool jungle to the south.

DHALPURNA MOUNTAINS

These starry mountains race down the center of the Reaches, hemming in the Tal-Yool jungle where they meet the Bastion Mountains to the north. They transform from a snowy blue in the north to a red granite in the south as the desert sun scorches their sides. The highest peaks in the Reaches are in this range.

DJURUM DESERT

A lonely sea of red, wind-torn sand dunes. The encircling mountains drain all rainfall away from this harsh, burning land.

Salt Flats. The site of an inland sea that boiled away long ago. The white salt pan stretches out flat and endless, taking on a pink hue in the morning sun.

DUCHY OF MONTMAR

The Duke's domain is a sunny land of rolling meadows and hills chased through by the swift-running Trematora River. The City of Masks is a shining jewel of civilization set on the coast where the river and sea merge. The duchy ends where the river touches the Lowland Moor.

Trematora River. This glittering river widens into an estuary where it meets the Last Sea.

GILZAI MOUNTAINS

A thick range of rusty, jagged peaks shot through with mazelike canyons and gorges. Their wide hook toward the south separates the Djurum Desert from the Kyzian Steppes.

GLOAMING, THE

A gnarled, misty forest of bogs and standing stones. Demons grow inside the cursed black marrow trees that sprout here.

Finimere Lake. The largest lake in the northern Reaches. Its dark, still waters are laced with the curse of The Gloaming.

ISLES OF ANDRIK

Frozen isles where the Last Sea crashes through sweeping fjords beneath the mighty Drake Peaks. Eternal night settles over these lands in the winter.

Drake Peaks. Vicious drakes rule these eternally snowy spires, while the feylike dverg toil at their work deep within them.

KYZIAN STEPPES

A bright land of tall, bobbing grass and endless skies. These wide grasslands transition the chilly northern Reaches into the scorching hot southern regions.

Cobai River. This turgid river snakes down from the Gilzai Mountains across the steppes.

Sardaquian Sea. The Cobai River empties into this seafoam-green lake rich with minerals.

LAST SEA, THE

A crashing ocean of frozen ice and storms to the north and warmer currents to the south. The sea is dotted with island chains and is said to be endless.

LOWLAND MOOR

Biting flies and mosquitoes swarm inside this fertile marsh. Sharp-toothed piranhas flit through its murky ponds, and antediluvian beasts who crawled out of the sea long ago still linger ere. The swamp's border along the Trematora river marks the northernmost edge of the Duchy of Montmar.

MORZOMOTHA

A lightless system of caves and tunnels far below the surface of the Western Reaches. Vast cathedral caves are as common as cramped, claustrophobic tunnels. The beings who live here are utterly alien to the surface, and the ways of life are anathema to sunborn creatures.

MYRE SWAMP

This wide bog leeches over the land south of The Gloaming, carrying some of the forest's curse along with it. Crocodiles, roving orcs, and pools of tarry peat threaten the unwary. Trade routes go out of their way to bend around this swamp, giving it the wide berth it has earned.

RIMESPIRE MOUNTAINS

These broad, dark mountains cluster along the northwestern coast of the Reaches. They capture frigid storms that blow in from the sea, delivering heavy snowfall. Glacial runoff feeds the Trematora river that flows south into the Duchy of Montmar.

SABLEWOOD

Thick, boreal forest and deep blue ponds cover this wide stretch of the northern Reaches. The woods push all the way to the north coast, finally peeling back at the foot of the Rimespire Mountains along the west coast.

Winterwash River. This cold, clear river runs from the northern Sablewood into Finimere Lake. It carries jostling slabs of ice in the spring.

SILENT MOUNTAINS

These eerily quiet, pale mountains stand to the southeast of the Djurum Desert. Not even the desert wind seems to blow through them.

TAL-YOOL JUNGLE

A dense, isolated valley of tropical rainforest hemmed in by the Dhalpurna and Bastion mountains. Most rainfall that reaches both mountain ranges flows inward toward the jungle's river basin, making it a lush region abundant with raucous wildlife. Ancient humans called the Itzalca dwell here.

Black River. The largest river by far in the Western Reaches. Its inky waters charge through the jungle in a violent cascade to the south, reaching distant lands in unknown places.



4327. GREYWALL PRIORY

In the deepest part of the woods lurks a grey-stoned priory with a pointed roof and arched, stained glass windows. 40 **Knights of St. Ydris** live here led by grim **Inquisitor Justinia Morvin**. Few know 160-year-old **St. Ydris** is still alive deep within the priory's catacombs, bound painfully (and willingly) in a magic circle to trap the mighty demon lord who possesses him. Initiates into the order gain their fell powers by drinking of his cursed blood and surviving. These knights swear to use their fiendish abilities to hunt demons, never losing control or embracing evil. Thus their oath: "I will walk the path between darkness and dawn, ever vigilant, sword drawn." They are sorely outnumbered.

4330. WOLF CAVE

A pack of 16 wolves lairs here. One wolf is favored by the demon prince **Almazzat**; it stands as tall as a horse and has six eyes (x2 level and damage). Anyone who leaves a worthy offering of flesh for it gains a random patron boon from Almazzat (once per person).

4425. CULTIST CAMP

20 cultists led by the charismatic firebrand **Torak Bain** (cultist) have recently set up camp here to make offerings to the dragon **Ixidian** (4324). The cultists stage ambushes on the path to Marin's Hold (4029) to capture sacrificial victims. Current captives are **Regina Pence**, a merchant from Marin's Hold, and her 3 guards.

4431. CORRUPTED HENGE

A henge of standing stones has been shifted out of alignment by the roots of a massive marrow tree. Spells are hard to cast within near distance of it. Inside the tree trunk rests **Taigolar**, a conjoined-twin dralech (treat as two combined) that erupts forth when it smells nearby prey.

4528. THE VILE WELL

The stench of rot gusts out of this mold-encrusted, lightless well. Inside, **Haldrin** the sorcerer (3826) is entangled in a nest of veins and tendrils that keep him alive, of sorts. Any creature who enters risks the same fate. 1,000 gp and a *Kytherian Cog* (*Shadowdark RPG*) rest on the well's fleshy, damp floor.

Witch Training With Uncle Grigor

Uncle Grigor is a masterful witch who will impart eldritch secrets to apprentices who impress him.

While he seems entirely crazy (he is), his madcap tests are also to teach fledgling witches fortitude, perseverance, and wit.

He relishes a good trick or unexpected solution and counts such mischief as a success.



TASKS

1. Eat six pronged leeches within one hour's time. Each time you eat one, you take 1d4 damage.
2. Bring Uncle Grigor a robe of the finest Alkeshi silk. It must be red. Not crimson, red. And blue.
3. Cast a witch spell Uncle Grigor has never seen before. It's a trick. You can't. He actually wants to see a diabolical mishap occur.
4. Take a giant leech around with you for one week without letting it die. It's a precious baby.

BENEFITS

If you complete a task, Uncle Grigor teaches you a witch secret. You gain one of the following benefits (once each):

BENEFITS	
d4	Benefit
1	Your dead familiars revive on their own after 1 day
2	Gain a +1 bonus to witch spellcasting checks
3	Your <i>broomstick</i> spell lasts 10 rounds instead of focus
4	Gain 1d4 HP

Lowland Moor

1130. SLAG TROLLS

Five **trolls** mill around this area, each claiming it as their sole territory. They eat the rusty iron armor and weapons found in abundance on the submerged bodies of invading warriors who died in battle along the coast long ago. The trolls all hate each other. Somehow, after ingesting the occasional magical sword or helm, they have become able to learn the *True Name* of any creature at a glance. They do not realize how formidable this is.

1528. WARRIOR'S CAIRN

A leaning, beehive-shaped pillar of stacked stones rises out of the bog. This is the ancient tomb of a warrior who died in a lost duel. Disturbing the cairn causes the warrior, now a **wight**, to rise and demand an honor duel. Fighting honorably and then yielding allows him to claim his final rest. His cairn holds a *+1 shield* of blackened oak carved with a wolf. Wolves will never attack its wielder except in self-defense.

1631. HIDDEN HOLLOWS

A group of 25 extremely elusive halflings have built their hollows beneath what look like totally ordinary stacks of mossy tree deadfall and rocks. They can disappear in a blink, leaving no trace. A youthful halfling called **Wendry Hogsfoot** is their champion truffle finder (see pg. 109). He's a supreme swamp survival expert, living undetected among wild boars for days as they root out truffles.

1823. GARLEY'S HUT

A young man named **Garley Bolt** lives in a raised thatched hut amid the mangroves that grow here. All of his cooking pots and water jars are overflowing with shells and fossils. Each day, he takes his rowboat out to the shallows and digs in the mud. He secretly feels madly driven to keep digging until he finds the **jet black shell** that calls to him in his dreams. Once found, he becomes murderously and paranoiacally possessive of it.

Survival Training With Wendry Hogsfoot

Wendry is a cheerful young halfling with brown, curly hair and sparkly blue eyes. He has an immense talent for stealth and survival, even among his naturally stealthy kin.

Characters who earn his trust may be able to learn survival skills from him. The hard part is noticing when Wendry is nearby in the first place.



TASKS

1. Sneak up on a sleeping boar and balance a wheel of cheese on its head without waking it. Wendry must witness it happen.

2. Trick a slag troll into telling you its *True Name*. Wendry will know if it's legit.

3. Survive three days and nights in the swamp without anything but your clothes and a stick.

4. Capture a swamp adder (cobra) alive and bring it to Wendry tied up in a burlap bag.

BENEFITS

If you complete a task, Wendry teaches you one of the following survival techniques (once each):

BENEFITS	
d4	Benefit
1	Your movement is not slowed by boggy terrain
2	1/day, become invisible for one round
3	Find 2 rations when you successfully forage
4	Detect any poison by smell within close range